

night), then build automations that activate that scene. This keeps your logic tidy and easy to edit.

The five rules of “non-annoying automation”

1. Always add a condition.
Example: motion lights only after sunset. Apple explicitly supports “only after sunset” for time-based automations. In Home Assistant, conditions are evaluated after triggers fire – so they’re your guardrails.
2. Always define an exit.
If a light turns on, also decide when it turns off (timer, no-motion window, or scene change).
3. Manual override is sacred.
Wall switch, voice command, or app control should always work – even if the automation is temporarily “wrong.”
4. Start small, then scale.
One room. One week. Then expand.
5. Name like a grown-up.
“LR Movie Scene”, “BR Goodnight Routine”, “Hall Motion Night”. No “Light 2”.

Step-by-step: The universal automation builder

Use this template for every automation in this chapter:

1. Pick the trigger
Time / sunset / motion / door / presence / device state.
2. Add a condition
After sunset, only when someone is home, only if light is off, only during quiet hours.
3. Define the action(s)
Turn on, set brightness, play audio, send notification, arm security, etc.
4. Set the exit
Off after 2 minutes, or revert to previous state at 11:30 PM.
5. Test like a QA person (not like a hopeful human)
Trigger it 10 times. If it annoys you twice, it will annoy your family daily.

Step-by-step: Where to create these

Google Home: Use Household Routines / scripted automations in the script editor for deeper logic. Google’s help pages describe using the script editor to write advanced household automations, and Google’s developer docs list supported starters/conditions/actions plus example scripts.

- Alexa: Alexa app → More → Routines → “+” → Add event (trigger) → Add actions (“Alexa will”) → Save.
- Apple Home: Home app → “+” → Add Scene / Add Automation; you can trigger automations by time, location, or an accessory change.
- Home Assistant: Settings → Automations & Scenes → create Scene / Automation. Automations are triggers + (optional) conditions + actions.

The 10 automations (starter recipes)

1) Motion night light

- Goal: Hallway/bathroom light turns on after sunset, turns off automatically.
- Ingredients: motion sensor + light (or smart switch).
- Trigger: motion detected.
- Condition: after sunset / during night hours.
- Actions: light ON at low brightness; OFF after X minutes no motion.



Steps

1. Place sensor facing the walking path (not curtains/fans).
2. Create automation: motion → turn on light.
3. Add condition: only after sunset (or 10 PM–6 AM). Apple supports sunset-based logic; HA supports conditions; Google/Alexa offer time conditions.
4. Add exit: turn off after 2–3 minutes of no motion.
5. Tune brightness: 20–40% so it doesn’t feel like interrogation lighting.
Upgrade: Add a second action: if motion repeats within 30 seconds, bump brightness to 60% (useful when carrying laundry).

2) “Goodnight” routine (the family favourite)

- Goal: One command or button puts the home into sleep mode.
- Ingredients: lights/switches, optional smart plug, optional door sensor.
- Trigger: voice phrase (“Goodnight”) or button press or scheduled time.
- Actions: lights off (except night lamp), reduce brightness, lock/arm (if available), set AC temp, enable quiet mode.

Steps:

1. Create a Goodnight Scene first: set the night lamp ON low; everything else OFF.
2. Create a routine/automation that activates that scene.
3. Add a condition: only runs when someone is home (presence) or after 9 PM. Apple supports location-based automations; Google scripted automations support home presence starters; HA supports presence conditions.